



Litmus test: With the World Cup six months away and the Asian Games, carrying an LA28 berth, just three weeks later, the Indian men's hockey team's patchy form is becoming a growing concern at precisely the wrong time. BISWARANJAN ROUT

FIH Pro League losses indicate Indian hockey's problems go beyond scoreline

India's Pro League results were bad. The performances were worse. A breakdown in basics, fitness and attitude has put Craig Fulton's team **under the microscope.**

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Four games, four losses, each worse than the previous one, at a venue that had been hitherto impenetrable, a fortress unconquered. Even by Indian hockey's traditionally slow-starting standards, this was a beginning to a crucial year that Craig Fulton and his boys would not have anticipated.

The Indian men's hockey team played its first four, and only, home

matches for 2026 at the Birs Munda Stadium in Rourkela, a city that once again did not disappoint when it came to supporting the sport. The crowds turned out in full strength night after night, even for non-India matches, despite the disappointing results.

On the field, however, it was a different story, and the scoreline was only one part of it, perhaps the smallest. What unfolded in the middle was nothing short of a horror show, with and without the stick. "Home defeats always hurt more

because there's an expectation. We want to win. We did not go out tonight, or last night, or the game before that, or the game before that, not to win. That's where the expectation and the frustration are real. (But) judge us on the big tournaments," Fulton said after the 4-2 loss to Argentina earlier this month.

It was almost a desperate cry from the usually stoic and controlled South African: do not judge him and his players in a hurry, give them time. In his defence, the team has been in